



Review
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REVIEWS

Fred C. Mench

Colin Renfrew. *Archaeology and Language: The Puzzle of Indo-European Origins*. New York: Cambridge University Press, 1987. Pp. xiv, 346. ISBN 0-521-35432-3.

Linguists and archaeologists have traditionally held that Proto-Indo-European was spoken around the mid-fifth millennium B.C., in a "homeland" (or at least a "staging area") in the south Russian steppe zone north and east of the Black Sea. The broad dispersal of the historically-attested Indo-European languages is said to result from migrations (over millennia) to the west, south and east from this region. Renfrew, however, considers the most significant staging area to have been eastern Anatolia, where a form of Proto-Indo-European was allegedly spoken as early as 7,000 B.C. With the migration of some speakers to central Greece in the mid-seventh millennium, and the establishment there of farming communities, the Indo-European languages of Europe reflect the gradual spread of farming (in tandem with the movement of these Indo-European speakers themselves) throughout Europe, radiating outward from central Greece.

Renfrew argues negatively against the orthodox view by impugning the methodologies traditionally used to reconstruct facts about prehistoric societies on the basis of linguistic data (especially "linguistic paleontology", "glotto-chronology", and Dumézilian "comparative mythology"). Renfrew raises valid (although timeworn) objections, but his argumentation is everywhere vitiated by a profound incompetence in linguistic matters.

Renfrew's positive arguments depend not on archaeological evidence but on the application, to his hypothetical scenario, of the "wave of advance" models of population diffusion and the spread of agriculture associated with the work of Ammerman and Cavalli-Sforza. Although this "processual" (as opposed to "catastrophic") approach enjoys increasing popularity among archaeologists, it is curious that Renfrew has ended up substituting for glottochronology a surprisingly similar "agrochronology", open to many of the same theoretical objections Renfrew himself raises.

The inflated jacket copy claims that Renfrew "initiates an original synthesis between modern historical linguistics and the New Archaeology of cultural process." But Renfrew merely shows that "there has hitherto been no valid methodology for matching the evidence obtained from. . .historical linguistics, with the material evidence of archaeology". Precisely what would constitute a valid methodology is never explained, and Renfrew's crude handling of linguistic theory and data precludes his work from being used as a model. Nevertheless, Renfrew's call to bring archaeology and linguistics "into some sort of constructive relationship" (should it be heeded by Western scholarship as it has by Soviet) may be the book's enduring contribution.

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